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Humanitarian crisis worsens across Iran, Lebanon, and Gaza as civilian casualties and displacement rise

War wages in the Middle East. People are losing their homes and their lives; desperate to find a safe haven in the ensuing violence. But is it truly safer for them anywhere?

Introduction

Over the past couple of years, the Middle East region has been in the middle of a war zone that, according to Politics Today, has already displaced a total of 4.1 million people within this region. With a rise in numbers, shelters are becoming overcrowded and lacking basic needs for refugees. The attacks have damaged infrastructure and brought shortages of water and electricity in various cities, leading to the development of impossible living conditions for the inhabitants of the cities. As refugees flee to neighboring countries, the countries they flee to become endangered as well and are demanded to migrate further for the sake of their well-being and the safety of their families in a conflict that is persistently chasing them, the innocent.

Overview

In modern times, the exact date that we can refer to as the beginning of this culmination of events that led to all the displacement and casualties we have perceived today is October 7th, 2023. This was the day when tensions between the Islamic Militant group Hamas and the country of Israel had reached the highest climax. The former, with intentions to spread Islam across the Middle East by dismantling its only Jewish state, organized a ruthless attack on this day and led to the deaths of 1,200 Israelis while 250 hostages were captured. In response to this single operation, Israel declares full-blown war and initiates their siege of the Palestinian city of Gaza. This act immediately led to mass displacement with the entirety of the northern section of the territory evacuated from what was to become a war zone.

According to the UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), by December 2023, over 20,000 were killed and 1.9 million (85% of Gaza's population at the time) had become displaced. According to Doctors Without Borders, at hospitals in Southern Gaza: 600 people had to share a single toilet, there were various cases of diarrhea in children due to poor hygiene conditions and an unleashing and rapid respiratory tract infection. This was just the beginning of the regional humanitarian crisis that was subject to happen in only a couple of years.

A day after the attack, Lebanon was also involved in the conflict with their own Islamic, Shiite militant organization, Hezbollah. This war on two fronts would be the drivers for massive bombardments of Gaza and the destruction of its infrastructure. By late 2024, deaths rose to the tens of thousands, approximately 2,600 children lost both their parents, and over 53,000 lost one parent. Furthermore, food shortages rose as well as the overloading of hospitals, preventing more people from being treated efficiently enough for minimal recovery. In this time, Gaza would be subject to a cycle of fighting, ceasefires, and temporary aid along with the involvement of other nations such as Iran and Lebanon in its support against the Jewish state.

The involvement of other nations, while meant to prevent Israel from continuing to attack the city of Gaza, were setting the millions of lives within other nations in danger. Airstrikes and assassinations in Lebanon had reached a state in which it suffered the deaths of thousands while Iran was subject to greater attacks. However, by 2025, the Palestinian city had become a wasteland of disease, famine, and death. The numbers of total casualties had risen to the hundreds of thousands as citizens were subject to diseases from the ingestion of the large Sheikh Radwan lagoon in northern Gaza. According to the BBC, there were 40,000 cases of Hepatitis A, which is approximately an increase of 46960% of the initial 85 cases at the beginning of the war. Gaza, ill-equipped and unable to treat the hundreds of thousands diagnosed with diarrheal diseases and respiratory infections, continues to grow as a study exemplifies the ratio between casualties from disease and combat wounds in the American Civil War being 8:1, respectively, to underscore the weight that disease has on the Middle Eastern conflict.

The year is now 2026, and Gaza, Lebanon and Iran are already amidst a full-scale regional war against Israel. In Lebanon, about 20% of the population has become displaced while hundreds have died. The United Nations International Children's Emergency Fund at USA (UNICEF USA) reported that 331 children have become injured, 214 children in Iran have been killed, and so have 116 in Lebanon. Israel has only suffered 4 deaths, and this comparison between the Muslim and the Jewish state reflects how one-sided this conflict has become and what it is subject to be if it continues. The United States' involvement has grown the magnitude of the displacements and casualties, with the New Humanitarian implying that the numbers amount to a total of 3.2 million people internally displaced in Iran —over a million households— along with a death toll of over 2,000. In comparison to Gaza, which has had 1.9 million displaced after two and a half years since October 7, 2023, the war with Iran and US started on February 28, 2026 has almost doubled the number of displacements.

The displacement of citizens in the three territories has now risen to over 4-5 million, and the deaths go up to over 100,000. There has been a societal collapse in Gaza, a collapse in education and infrastructure in Lebanon, and now an entire war between the United States and Iran. Even five months after a ceasefire was announced in Gaza, there have still been over 680 killed from nearby airstrikes and a reliance on canned food as about 20,000 patients still wait for treatments and evacuation despite the city's inability to properly attend to them. Camps are drowned in muddy waters while there are such numbers of people coming in and settling in a place where they can be safer from the attacks. Based on the recent numbers compared to the past, the trajectory of the conflict is much worse and it may involve more nations in the long term.

Perspectives

Officials at the Pentagon said that just the first six days of attacks has cost the US an excess of $11.3 billion, to which US President Donald Trump replied he wasn't willing to back down. He threatened Iran to bring them "back to the stone ages" as he projected another two or three weeks of further intensified conflict as he confirmed the war was "near completion". He was willing to leave the North Atlantic Treaty Organization for this reason, criticizing this alliance for being against his decisions. Now that the US, a major superpower, has become involved, the conflict has yet to cause greater humanitarian issues in the Middle East.

A social survey published by the Pew Research Center found that in a sample of 1,001 Israelis conducted between March and April 2024, 34% have indicated that the war can go further. Furthermore, 67% show beliefs that Israel is likely to succeed in their efforts against Gaza and the rest of the Middle East. A majority of Israeli adults were worried about the future of the war, with 61% worried it will expand to other nations —which it already has as of 2026—, and 68% worry the war will continue to exist for longer. "There is no policy of starvation in Gaza, and there is no starvation in Gaza. We enable humanitarian aid throughout the duration of the war to enter Gaza – otherwise, there would be no Gazans." said Benjamin Netanyahu in July 2025, who blamed Hamas for Gaza's inability to receive aid. Now, he announces that Israel is at their “halfway point” thanks to alliances and aiming to form more against Iran.

Meanwhile, Palestine during this time was being provided with food trucks, causing hungry people to swarm around them. According to Israel’s military, as of July 21, 2025, 95,435 trucks had entered Gaza since the war’s beginning. This is equal to an average of 146 trucks a day, which is significantly under the 500-600 that the United Nations reported was necessary. Witnesses and health workers in Gaza have implied that Israeli forces have opened fire against them as they gathered food from the trucks. In response, the military of Israel stated that these were warning shots meant to disperse threats within the crowd. The nation continues to report the prevalence of ceasefire violations by Israel, as well as the destruction of 80% of their infrastructure and the mass number of Palestinian casualties since October 7, 2023.

The same or worse has been for Lebanon and Iran. According to the Lebanese Health Ministry, at least 850 have been killed and 1 million have been internally displaced. Hezbollah, as a response from the death of former Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khemenei, sent drones and large-scale rockets as retaliation. However, this only received greater offense from Israel, who had begun to target strongholds of the Lebanese military organization. Buildings in Beirut, Lebanon had begun to be attacked, signaling the danger that the citizens have become part of. "The fear and anxiety is through the roof amongst the people living in Lebanon. Internally displaced people ... they don't know if tomorrow they're gonna be able to send their kids to school. They don't know if they're gonna eat tonight. They don't know if they're gonna have any

form of future." This was said by CARE international coordinations communicator at Lebanon Cyril Bassil, who has asserted the drastic deterioration of the situation the country was part of.

Iran, however, has taken a firm stance against its aggressors. The Center for Strategic and International Studies has implied that in aiming to restore their deterrence, Tehran's war strategy has been the avoidance of calibrated retaliation to prevent uncontrollable situations. They have mined the Strait of Hormuz as a threat that could put a chokehold in the world's oil supply, and these types of decisions express the severity of the war in Iran after the death of their supreme leader and the involvement of the US. Nevertheless, the nation, in the words of the Middle East Council on Global Affairs, "has suffered several political and military setbacks over the past two years". It expects a prolonged conflict and for the opposing nations to suffer the consequences of waging such a war despite the millions that have been evacuated and are internally displaced within their nation.

Implications

The war that began on October 7, 2023 has continued to worsen and affect more nations in 2026, which has led to greater numbers of homes and lives as people struggle to live wherever they try to relocate. Other Middle Eastern nations have failed to hold such magnitudes of refugees, and aid has become significantly diminished with greater individuals in need as well as blockade systems being set in motion to prevent international organizations from providing necessities for the affected.

Regardless of the Strait of Hormuz's situation affecting 20% of global oil supply, of oil prices rising to $100 a barrel, or of any form of rivalry between the nations, the humanitarian crisis in the Middle East has reached a peak so negative that there is no indication it will end and that the numbers of displacements and deaths will rise as the ones of funding for nations in need and aid reports decrease significantly. The destruction at hand may reach a point of nuclear warfare that will produce numbers that may as well cause the world to fall unconscious.

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